



SUVASHISH MULLICK

RESISTANCE: Intellectuals demonstrate in Kolkata (left); Banerjee trying to enter Nandigram (below)

Nandigram. Firing on a gathering of villagers, the police killed 14 people, women and children included. There has been an uneasy calm since then.

CPI(M) then drew up a plan. Late October, Bhattacharya said he had sought the Centre's help and asked for CRPF deployment in the troubled areas. Meanwhile, cadres prepared to regain the lost ground. Last weekend, the police were asked to stay away from Nandigram and CRPF was detained outside the area till the cadres completed their work. CRPF is trying to restore peace but the profusion of red flags tells a different story.

It is a story as old as the communists in power. Even before they completed their first five years in the Writers' Buildings, the Marxists had mastered the art of violent repression. Towards the end of 1970s, CPI(M) cadres had massacred hundreds of tribals in Morichjhapi, Sunderbans, calling them "illegal settlers". Over two decades have passed since CPI(M) cadres burnt to death 17 Anand Margis including a woman in Kolkata. Thousands were killed as the Marxists took over the anti-Naxal campaigns from the previous Congress government. In the last 30 years of the Left's uninterrupted rule, few CBI inquiries have succeeded in actually convicting those accused of heinous crimes. The March 14 killings were the result of people's resistance to forceful acquisition of land for industrialisation.

In party General Secretary Prakash Karat's words, CPI(M) had "waited for 11 months". The siege of Nandigram materialised last Saturday as Karat and his counterpart from CPI, A.B. Bardhan, sat down for lunch with Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Congress President Sonia Gandhi in Delhi. As CPI(M) cadres went about killing villagers, burning and looting homes and shops in Nandigram, Karat continued his diatribe against US imperialism from the comfort of the prime minister's residence, the crispy autumn sun adding to the halo of this drawing room revolutionary. While the images of murderous cadres on victory parade shocked the country, CPI(M) leaders met in the Capital to blame



"If anybody thinks that they can take away Nandigram from us by force, they are wrong."

PRAKASH KARAT, GENERAL SECRETARY, CPI(M)



SUBIR HALDER

acres of land, would be required for the Salim Group's SEZ in Nandigram. This would have meant rehabilitating entire villages, and the Government didn't have any clear plan on compensation. But it wasn't overly worried because Nandigram was primarily a Marxist stronghold. Marxist MP from Haldia, Lakshman Seth, announced on January 3 that Bhanga-bera, Sonachura and Garchakraberia villages would have to hand over their

land for the proposed SEZ. TC, which had been trying to get the locals on its side, took advantage of the situation and formed BUPC along with members of the Jamait-e-Ulema. BUPC blocked access to two panchayat blocks and cordoned off the area, packing the CPI(M) cadres off to neighbouring Khejuri, separated from Nandigram by a canal. On March 14, Bhattacharya sent a huge posse of police force to regain administrative control in